

THE MOVE

Exact phrase -> small comment -> natural follow-up. -> You called it 'oddly freeing' — freeing how? -> 'Hidden rules' is a good phrase. What are you noticing? -> When you say 'messy', do you mean emotionally or logistically? -> 'Not quite rig...

START HERE

Pick one distinctive word they used and ask '[word] how?' or 'What do you mean by [word]?'

SAY THIS

Quick	"Weird how?"
Warm	"That word sounds like it matters."
Professional	"When you say 'misaligned', what's the part that isn't lining up?"
Conflict-softening	"When you say it felt 'dismissive', what did that look like from your side?"
Social / dating	"'Chaotic but fun' is a strong phrase. What happened?"
Digital / text	"'Oddly freeing' caught my eye — freeing how?"

AVOID

- The word is too private, shame-laden, traumatic, or potentially embarrassing to repeat directly
- They used the word jokingly and repeating it would sound like mockery
- You are tempted to use their wording as evidence against them

REMEMBER

Use their words as handles, not hooks.